When multiple viewpoints come to the table, they are normally intermediated by informal systems of power. The persons in the room are all in a repeated game, and there is a give and take across many different elements of these relationships. It is all too easy for this process to collapse into an autocratic arrangement, where all power is placed with one or two people. Our cultural mores in India tend to give disproportionate power to the oldest or richest person in the room.

The give and take which occurs in these informal meetings is part of a larger game between these individuals. A person may sacrifice the interests of a certain constituency in one particular meeting in return for pay-offs in unrelated settings. Each person who gets a seat on the table has the opportunity to non-transparently make certain trade-offs. In the limit, persons in the room sacrifice the interests of constituents or the public interest in return for personal gains.

How can conflicts be channelled into better decisions? Formal voting systems are a great tool for improving the quality of the discourse. It is useful to think of three stages of a meeting. Stage 1 is an approximate statement of position, by various persons, and a free-format debate. Stage 2 consists of defining sharp propositions. Stage 3 consists of voting on them. What prevents persons in the room from arranging side payments in exchange for votes? Public disclosure of each vote, with a rationale statement, helps ensuring personal accountability of each person for the position taken.

In India, two formal voting systems are in place: benches of judges in the judiciary, and the Monetary Policy Committee (MPC).

In the MPC, the stage 2 is clear. Every meeting of the MPC has a narrow range of discrete choices that can be taken. In this case, the propositions that require voting upon are well understood. An MPC meeting then involves only stage 1 and stage 3.

The Indian MPC has three votes for RBI staff and three votes for outsiders. When there is a tie, the RBI governor has a casting vote. This suffers from the problem that the two RBI staffers are likely to be deferential towards the third vote, which is the RBI governor’s. Thus, in